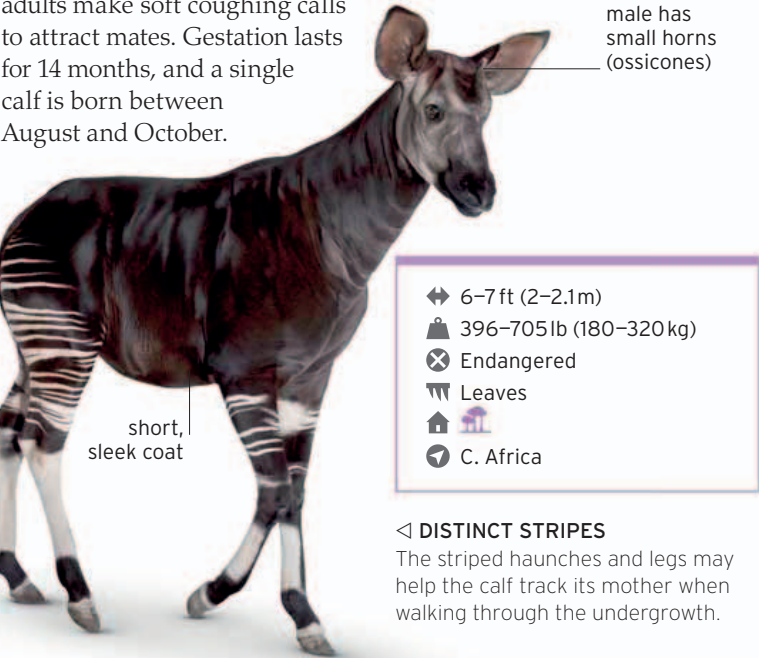


Okapi

Okapia johnstoni

The closest relative of the giraffe, the okapi lives a solitary life, following well-trodden paths through dense forests. Like the giraffe, it uses its long, prehensile tongue to strip leaves from twigs. Okapis gather to mate at the end of the spring rainy season. Although silent at other times, adults make soft coughing calls to attract mates. Gestation lasts for 14 months, and a single calf is born between August and October.



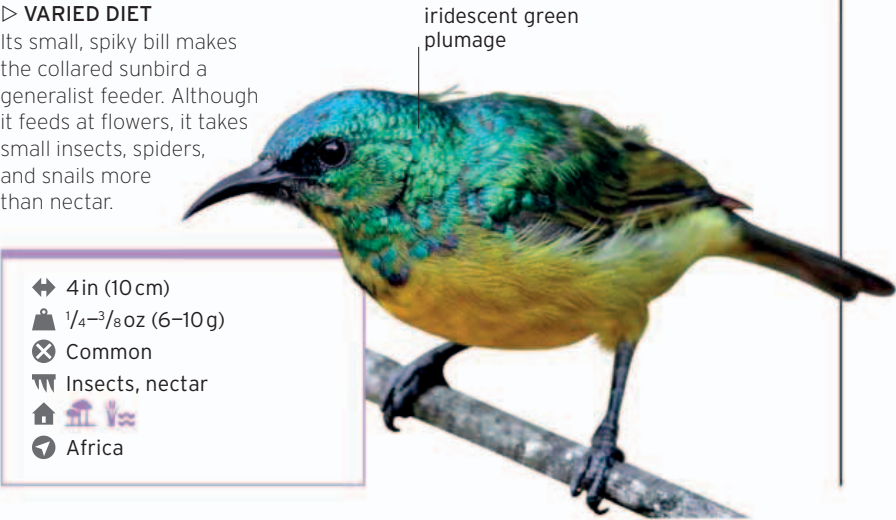
Collared sunbird

Anthreptes collaris

This sunbird darts between flowers growing on tangled creepers and bushes at the forest edge. Acrobatically searching through cobwebs, dead leaves, and foliage, it gleans whatever it can eat. It suspends a tiny purse of plant fibers, leaf mold, and moss, knitted together with cobwebs, to hold two eggs, which hatch after 12 days.

▷ **VARIED DIET**

Its small, spiky bill makes the collared sunbird a generalist feeder. Although it feeds at flowers, it takes small insects, spiders, and snails more than nectar.



Emperor scorpion

Pandinus imperator

Aptly named, this fearsome-looking creature is the world’s biggest scorpion, although at least one more slender species is longer. Its front end is dominated by immense clawed pincers while, at the back, the tail-like telson is frequently curled menacingly forward over the body to display the curved stinger. However, the large size does not make this scorpion more deadly—its venom is not as potent as some other, smaller scorpions. A sting is painful to humans, but has few further ill effects. The emperor scorpion reserves its venom for self-defense or to incapacitate prey, and uses the crushing power of its pincers to kill it.

Feeling its way

Emperor scorpions are nocturnal and have poor eyesight. Touch-sensitive hairs are especially thick on the pincers and legs. These are used to detect prey in the dark, along with help from the comblike pectines under the body that are used to sense vibrations running through the ground.

Mating involves an elaborate dance, where the male leads the female by her pincers to a patch of flat ground where sperm can be transferred. After seven to nine months, she gives birth to between nine and 32 live young, which are white in color.

